

Imperial Construction Inspired by Jiangnan Landscapes

276 years ago, Emperor Qianlong of the Qing Dynasty made multiple southern inspection tours, where the delicate and elegant landscapes of the Jiangnan region left a profound impression on him. This longing eventually translated into a construction project on the western outskirts of Beijing—the Summer Palace came into being. This imperial garden ingeniously drew on the exquisite layout of the "Su Causeway" and "Bai Causeway" of West Lake in Hangzhou, built the West Causeway on Kunming Lake, and accurately reproduced the graceful artistic conception of Jiangnan water towns. At the same time, it integrated the majestic momentum of northern imperial gardens, ultimately becoming a masterpiece that combines both "grandeur" and "elegance", serving as an exclusive retreat for emperors and empresses to escape the summer heat, handle state affairs, and enjoy sightseeing.



Draft design of the Summer Palace

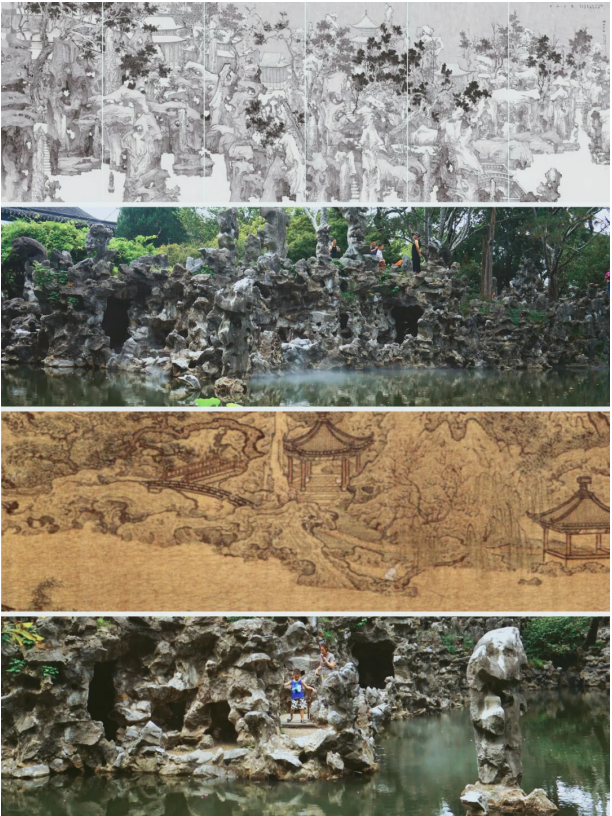
Classical Charm and Technological Innovation

What is particularly fascinating is that Haidian District, where the Summer Palace is located, has risen to become a core engine of China's technological innovation in the past 20 years. The cluster of science and technology enterprises in Zhongguancun, the scientific research strength of top universities, and the R&D positions for cutting-edge technologies form a profound dialogue across time and space with the classical aesthetics of the Summer Palace here.



Master Plan of the Summer Palace

Precisely because of this, I have conceived the idea of reproducing the space of classical Jiangnan gardens—deeply integrating this classical charm with modern places such as work and residence. When workers devote themselves to R&D and innovation here, they only need to step out for a moment to enter the landscape scroll of the Summer Palace, find a resting place for inspiration in the infiltration of classical aesthetics, and let their tired thoughts slowly unfold amidst the lakes, mountains, pavilions, and terraces.



Stones in Chinese Classical Garden

Typeplogy Analysis

In this research, nine classic Jiangnan gardens were chosen as the primary case studies, covering a diverse range of scales, styles, and historical contexts to ensure the comprehensiveness of the analysis. A rigorous abstraction methodology was adopted: first, the complex spatial configurations of these gardens were simplified by eliminating non-essential elements such as specific plant species, ornamentation, and material textures. Then, by mapping the built structures, open spaces, water bodies, and pathways, the underlying spatial figure-ground relationships were systematically identified, extracted, and documented, which provided critical insights into the traditional design philosophy that balances enclosure and openness in Jiangnan garden architecture.



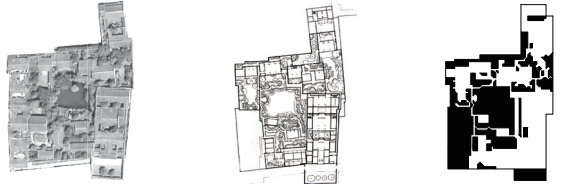
01 Tuisi Garden

It is a representative small Jiangnan garden of the late Qing Dynasty. Its name comes from Zuo Zhuan, reflecting the owner's introspection after retirement. Centered on water, it features a compact layout with rich spatial layers.



02 Geyuan Garden

A classic private garden of Yangzhou salt merchants in the Qing Dynasty, named after the owner's courtesy name and the abundant bamboo (the character "Ge" resembles bamboo leaves). Famous for its four-season rockeries made of different stones, creating distinct seasonal scenery.



03 Master of Nets Garden

A delicate Suzhou classical garden, originally named "Fisherman's Seclusion". "Net Master" means fisherman, symbolizing the owner's longing for seclusion. Small in size but with a harmonious integration of water, land, pavilions and rockeries.



04 The Lingering Garden

One of Suzhou's four great classical gardens, its name implies "lingering in admiration". It is known for layered spaces and exquisite stone scenery, divided into four parts with diverse styles (water scenery in the center, buildings in the east, forests in the west, pastoral scenes in the north).



05 Humble Administrator's Garden

Suzhou's largest classical garden and one of China's four great classical gardens. Its name comes from Pan Yue's works, expressing the owner's self-deprecating seclusion. Dominated by water (1/3 of the area), it presents the free and natural charm of Jiangnan water towns.



06 Yongcui Mountain Villa

A mountain villa garden on Huqiu Mountain, Suzhou. "Yongcui" means "embracing emeralds", referring to its green mountain surroundings. Built along the terrain, it blends man-made structures with natural mountain scenery.



07 Jichang Garden

A historic Jiangnan garden at the foot of Huishan Mountain, Wuxi. Its name means "sending joy", reflecting the owner's enjoyment of natural scenery. It skillfully borrows the scenery of Huishan Mountain and Erquan Spring, with poetic mountain-water integration.



08 Lion Forest Garden

A Suzhou garden famous for labyrinthine Taihu stone rockeries shaped like lions (also linked to Buddhist symbolism). Its rockeries have winding paths, making it a unique "rockery garden" in Suzhou



09 Canglang Pavilion

Suzhou's oldest existing classical garden, named after Chu Ci, expressing the owner's indifference to fame. Built on a hill (unlike water-centered Suzhou gardens), it has a waterside corridor and borrows external scenery skillfully.